

Chapter 5: The Man Behind the Door

Dr. Soren Vale should have been dead.

If Mara had crossed more than two thousand years into the future, then everyone she had ever known was gone. Geneva was gone. The Lumen Gate was gone. The glass chamber where her real body had lain was gone.

And yet his voice came through the sealed door.

“Mara,” Vale said. “Step away from the Accord officers.”

Kael’s hand moved to his coat.

The woman with the glass ring pulled Eliya back.

Eliya resisted, not because she wanted the door, but because she wanted to see it.

Who is that?

Mara could not answer.

Her throat had closed around the name.

Vale spoke again, calm as ever.

“You are frightened. That is expected. They will tell you I lied to you.”

Kael’s face hardened.

“He is not here,” he said.

“I can hear him.”

“That does not mean he is here.”

The red lights pulsed across the chamber. The Sol family file collapsed above the crescent table, folding into locked symbols.

The door shook.

Something struck it from the outside.

The woman with the ring whispered, “Signal breach.”

Kael did not look away from the door. “Can you trace it?”

“Not before entry.”

Entry.

Mara felt the word land in Eliya.

Entry meant body.

Entry meant mind.

Entry meant one more thing forcing its way in.

“Open the door,” Vale said.

Mara’s heart lurched.

The command was meant for her.

“Mara,” Kael said. “Do not answer him.”

“He can hear me?”

“No. But he knows you will respond.”

The door struck again.

A thin white line appeared down its center.

Vale’s voice remained gentle.

“Ask yourself who restrained you. Who threatened removal. Who showed you records they could easily manipulate.”

Kael gave a humorless laugh. “Origin rhetoric.”

“Ask who killed your body,” Vale said.

Mara went still.

Vale knew exactly where to cut.

“They will blame me,” he continued. “But your origin body failed because the host rejected insertion. The Accord knows this.”

Liar, Eliya said.

“You don’t know that,” Mara whispered.

I know what his voice does to you.

That hurt because it was true.

Vale had always sounded steady. During testing. During grief interviews. During every anniversary of her father's disappearance. He had told Mara that Jonas Venn's sacrifice opened the door to humanity's future.

He sounded steady now.

Like a man who had already chosen which truths mattered.

Kael stepped closer. "He is using memory hooks."

"What?"

"Phrases tied to loyalty. Grief. Your father."

Another impact hit the door.

The white line widened.

The woman with the ring dragged symbols through the air. A pale circle opened beneath their feet.

"Emergency transit," she said. "Now."

Eliya stepped back.

No.

Mara felt the fear before she understood it.

A platform.

Sirens.

A child screaming.

A woman's hand slipping away.

Eliya's mother.

Mara recoiled from the memory.

"I'm sorry."

Not now, Eliya said.

Kael reached toward them. "Eliya, we have to go."

The sealed door split open.

A figure stood outside.

It wore the uniform of an archive technician, but its movements were too smooth. Its head lifted. Its eyes were silver and empty.

Then its mouth opened.

Vale's voice came out.

"Mara. Come here."

Eliya stopped breathing.

The woman with the ring whispered, "Remote occupation."

Kael stepped between them and the door.

The occupied technician smiled.

"Mara," Vale said, "I can bring you home."

Home.

The word struck deep.

Geneva. Copenhagen rain. Her mother's apartment. Her father's recordings. Her own body waiting under glass.

Then Kael's earlier words returned.

Your origin body failed.

Earth declared you dead.

Home was not behind that door.

Eliya whispered, Do not believe him.

Mara almost laughed.

"You hate me."

Yes.

"But you want me to trust you?"

Yes.

"Why?"

Because he wants the body.

The technician stepped forward.

Kael raised his hand. A blade of blue-white light unfolded from his wrist.

“Do not move.”

Vale ignored him.

“Eliya Sol is not your prison, Mara,” he said. “She is your passage.”

Eliya’s horror twisted through them.

The lock.

Jonas Venn’s recording returned.

She is not your destination. She is the lock.

Mara stared at the silver-eyed technician.

“What is Eliya supposed to open?”

For the first time, Vale paused.

Only for a heartbeat.

But Kael saw it.

So did Eliya.

“You have been exposed to corrupted information,” Vale said.

“That is not an answer.”

The technician lunged.

Kael moved first.

His blade cut through the air without touching flesh. The technician convulsed. Vale’s voice shattered into static.

The woman grabbed Eliya’s hand.

“Now!”

The transit circle brightened.

Eliya froze.

Mara felt the old memory rise again: sirens, falling, her mother's hand gone.

Mara did not push.

Eliya, she said inwardly.

No.

"I won't take your body."

More figures appeared beyond the broken door.

Archive staff.

Officers.

Civilians.

All with blank silver eyes.

Mara understood.

Vale had not come through a door.

He had come through people.

Eliya, Mara said. I need you to move us.

Silence.

Then Eliya answered.

If you touch my memories again, I will kill us both.

"I believe you."

Their body became still.

Not empty.

Shared.

Eliya moved the legs.

Mara held back the panic.

Together, they stepped into the light.

Vale screamed through a dozen mouths.

The transit shaft swallowed them.

For one instant, Mara felt the body fall.

Then white became black.

They opened their eyes in a dark room filled with sleeping bodies suspended upright in glass.

Hundreds of them.

Maybe thousands.

Every body had silver eyes.

And from the far end of the room, Vale's voice whispered:

“Welcome to the future they buried.”